CSC 101 A: Introduction to Computing
Fall 2026

Instructor Information

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Student Hours: MWF 10:00–11:00 am and MTF 2:00–3:00 pm

Class Information

Course: CSC 101 A: Introduction to Computing
Credits: 1 credit; catalog format: (1-0-1)
Prerequisites/Restrictions: Intended for first-year Computer Science majors. May not be taken after CSC 120 for credit toward the Computer Science major.
Dates: August 24–December 11, 2026
Time: Wednesdays, 1:00–1:50pm
Classroom: McAllister Hall 233
Canvas: Canvas course page
Final Exam: Wednesday, December 9, 2026, 11:00 am–1:00 pm

Important announcements will be made through Discord Announcements. It is your responsibility to check Discord, Canvas, the course GitHub repository, and related course resources regularly throughout the semester. A detailed schedule of class topics, activities, and assignments will be maintained on the course repository README and on Canvas.

Course Description

(1-0-1) An introduction to essential tools, techniques, and computing concepts that are used and taught throughout the Computer Science major. This course is intended for first-year Computer Science majors. May not be taken after CSC 120 for credit toward the Computer Science major.

Vision and Purpose

Our purpose: prepare for the study of Computer Science. This course gives first-year Computer Science majors early practice with the tools, habits, and core ideas they will repeatedly encounter in later courses. Rather than focusing on a single programming language, the course emphasizes the practical computing environment: accounts, software setup, command-line work, version control, productivity tools, AI-assisted work habits, and the computational ideas that connect these topics.

Core Tools, Skills, and Concepts

Tools	Virtual machines; Linux; Git and GitHub; Markdown; Visual Studio Code; AI coding assistants; Excel and productivity tools.
Skills	Touch typing; command-line usage; version control; spreadsheet modeling; prompt-and-test workflows; file system management; responsible AI use.
Concepts	AI agents and human oversight; Boolean logic and satisfiability; data representation; file formats; quadtrees; formal grammars; L-systems; portfolios and computing trajectories.

Student Learning Outcomes and Assessment Measures

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

- Work with tools commonly used in software development and computer science. This outcome is measured through in-class participation and weekly activities.
- Demonstrate basic proficiency in prerequisite skills for studying computer science. This outcome is measured through completion of online learning modules.
- Reproduce the operation of representative computational algorithms. This outcome is measured through weekly puzzle challenges.

Textbook, Resources, and Technology Use in Class

Textbook/Readings: No required textbook is listed. Readings, modules, and activities will be provided through Canvas, the course GitHub repositories, LinkedIn Learning, Typing.com, GitHub, selected online tools, and other course resources.
Required Technology/Software: Students will work with virtual machines, Linux, productivity software, version control systems, development tools, GitHub, Visual Studio Code, Excel, online typing practice resources, and approved AI tools used under the course AI policy.

Phone and Device Policies

A laptop or classroom computer is necessary for setup activities, online modules, command-line practice, spreadsheets, version control, and other course-related work. Phones are generally not needed and should be put away during class unless the instructor gives permission or there is an urgent reason. Please use technology for course work rather than unrelated browsing, messaging, or entertainment.

Class Attendance and Participation

Class attendance is expected and required. Missing three or more classes without justifiable reason, advance notice, and/or appropriate documentation will be considered excessive absence and may be grounds for being administratively withdrawn from the course. See the Berry Viking Code for class attendance policies.

You are responsible for any material covered, work assigned, or course changes made during a class you miss. Because this course meets only once per week and relies heavily on in-class activities, each absence represents a substantial portion of the course.

Late Submissions

The original syllabus does not list a separate late-submission policy. Unless otherwise announced, assignment deadlines and submission expectations will be stated in Canvas, on the course website, or in class. If you anticipate a problem meeting a deadline, communicate with the instructor as early as possible.

Collaboration Policy

You are encouraged to discuss course ideas, general problem-solving approaches, tools, and concepts with classmates. However, do your own work. Do not look at others' work, use it to complete your own, or pass it off as yours. Do not share your own work in a way that allows another student to pass it off as their work. When you use outside sources, including generative AI, give credit clearly.

Academic Integrity and AI Usage

Students are expected to have read and understood the rules governing academic integrity in the Viking Code and Berry College Catalog. Academic dishonesty will not be tolerated.

Do your own work. Do not look at others' work, use it to complete your own, or pass it off as yours. Give credit to all sources, including generative AI. If you use AI or any outside resource to inform your work, you are responsible for understanding what you submit and for explaining how the resource was used. AI may not be used to replace the learning, practice, or demonstration of skill that an assignment is designed to develop.

Violations will result in a negative point penalty per assignment and notification of the Provost, according to Berry College Catalog policy. If you are unsure whether a particular form of help is allowed, ask before submitting.

Evaluation Components

Your final grade in the course will be based on completion of the components below and your earned point score.

Component	Points	Notes
Attendance	14	Attend class meetings; excessive absence may lead to administrative withdrawal.
Touch Typing	5	Demonstrate touch typing around 50–60 words per minute or show regular weekly practice.
LinkedIn Learning	7	Complete assigned modules through Berry SSO at https://myapps.berry.edu. Each completed module is worth 1 point.
Activity 1: AI Trading Agent Simulation	10	Submit a complete trading log (5 points) and reflection (5 points).
Weekly Challenges	16	Eight challenges—GHP, SAT, LSH, WTQ, XGB, EXT, QDT, and LSY—are worth 2 points each.
Activity 2: AI Cheating and Impostor Hunt	5	Participate in the AI cheating/Impostor Hunt activity and complete the assigned reflection.
Linux Jeopardy	4	Contribute questions and participate in the Linux Jeopardy activity.
Total	61	Maximum course points.

Grading Scale

These thresholds will not be raised, but they may be lowered by the end of the semester if adjustments to the schedule are made.

To earn	A	B	C	D	F
Points required	50	46	42	36	< 36

To earn an A in the course, students must also meet the following minimum requirements:

- 12 points of attendance, meaning no more than two absences.
- Complete at least six of the seven LinkedIn Learning activities.
- Weekly typing practice demonstrated, or achievement of a 60+ WPM rate with an 85%+ accuracy rate.

If any of these thresholds is not met, the maximum final letter grade in the course will be capped at a B.

Let's Talk!

Questions about scheduling, assignments, course material, tools, or topics you want to explore more deeply are welcome. For personal scheduling issues, individual concerns, feedback, or academic advice, email the instructor or come to student hours.

Accommodation

The Academic Success Center provides accessibility resources, including academic accommodations, to students with diagnosed differences and/or disabilities. If you need accommodations for this or other classes, please visit https://www.berry.edu/ASC for information and resources. You may also reach out at 706-233-4080. Please note that faculty are not required, as part of any temporary or long-term accommodation, to distribute recordings of class sessions.

Academic Success Resources

The Academic Success Center provides free peer tutoring and individual academic consultations to all Berry College students. The ASC session schedule is available on the ASC website: https://www.berry.edu/ASC. The goal of these meetings is to help students study smarter, not harder.

Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

We are committed to a climate of mutual respect and full participation. My goal as your instructor is to create a learning environment that is usable, equitable, inclusive, and welcoming. If aspects of the instruction or design of this course create barriers to your inclusion, learning, accurate assessment, or achievement, you are invited to meet with the instructor to discuss strategies beyond formal accommodations that may support your success.

Counseling Services

If at any point during the semester you feel overwhelmed with class work, experience problems with physical or mental health, or face any other serious struggle, please seek help. The Counseling Center at Berry offers individual and group support. The Counseling Center website is https://www.berry.edu/student-life/life-on-campus/counseling-center/; it is located at the Ladd Center and can be contacted at 706-236-2259.

Respect Policy

I respect your time:

- I will come prepared to help you understand the course material and prepare for assignments and assessments.
- I am here to help you; let me know what I can do to support your success.

Respect my time:

- Be on time to class.
- Pay attention when I am talking with the class.
- Come prepared by doing the work and seeking help when needed.

Respect each other:

- Do not be disruptive. If you need to take a call or text someone, take it outside.
- Work with each other to find solutions and deepen understanding.
- Allow one another to make mistakes; mistakes are part of learning.
- Use respectful language when talking with one another.

Tips for Success

- Attend every class and arrive ready to participate.
- Keep up with weekly activities; a one-credit course can still require regular work outside class.
- Practice touch typing consistently rather than cramming near the end of the semester.
- Begin online modules and weekly tasks early, especially when an activity uses time-limited access or shared resources.
- Ask questions during class, student hours, or by email when a tool, command, or concept is unclear.
- Keep your GitHub work organized so that your repository contributions show clear progress.

Tentative Schedule

This schedule is subject to change. The live schedule of class topics, activities, and assignments is maintained in the course repository README and on Canvas. Abbreviations used below: GHP = GitHub Pages; AIT = AI Trading Agent Simulation; SAT = Boolean Satisfiability problem; LSH = Linux Scavenger Hunt; WTQ = Write the Question; XGB = Student grade book worksheet; EXT = File forensics; QDT = Quadtree decoding; LSY = L-system design.

Date	Class Topic(s)	Weekly Activity / Notes
Wednesday, August 26, 2026	Welcome and setup	Course setup; operating-system tips; begin typing practice.
Wednesday, September 2, 2026	Git and GitHub; Markdown; Visual Studio Code	GHP; Git and GitHub practice; continue typing practice.
Wednesday, September 9, 2026	Vibe Coding: build a small chess game	Prompting, testing, debugging, and finishing the capture-the-king chess activity.
Wednesday, September 16, 2026	Agentic AI and its danger	AI agent risk model; red-team/blue-team activity; Activity 1 introduced.
Wednesday, September 23, 2026	Boolean logic and satisfiability	SAT; continue Git and GitHub practice and typing.
Wednesday, September 30, 2026	Linux and the command-line interface	LSH; WTQ; Linux command-line practice.
Wednesday, October 7, 2026	Productivity: Excel, Kanban, and Visual Studio Code	XGB; Excel and productivity workflows.
Wednesday, October 14, 2026	Linux Jeopardy	Linux review game; EXT file forensics challenge.
Wednesday, October 21, 2026	Activity 1: Trading with AI reflection	Submit the trading log and reflect on AI-assisted decision-making risks.
Wednesday, October 28, 2026	Quadtrees	QDT; developer career paths and certifications.
Wednesday, November 4, 2026	L-systems and formal grammars	LSY; formal grammar design.
Wednesday, November 11, 2026	Activity 2: AI Cheating and Impostor Hunt	Public-facing AI integrity activity; investigate AI-assisted cheating patterns.
Wednesday, November 18, 2026	Activity 2: Impostor Hunt reflection	Reflection and synthesis; connect AIT, agentic AI, and academic integrity.
Wednesday, November 25, 2026	Thanksgiving Holiday	No class.
Wednesday, December 2, 2026	Conclusion; portfolio; trajectory outlook	Portfolio wrap-up and next steps in computing.
Wednesday, December 9, 2026	Final examination, 11:00 am–1:00 pm	Attend the final examination at the scheduled time.

Weekly Activity Timeline

Approximate outside/class activity time blocks include operating-system tips, Git and GitHub modules, Linux command-line modules, Excel practice, developer career-path material, typing practice, weekly challenges, the AI Trading Agent Simulation, and the AI Cheating and Impostor Hunt activity. The course repository README is the source of truth for the current topic sequence; Canvas is the source of truth for due dates and submission instructions.